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NEWSPAPER

16th July, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

29th WEEK



NATO & USA VS OTHERS

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

16th JULY, 2018

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Transatlantic rift

Donald Trump shakes the NATO consensus further by talking defence budgets

The summit of North Atlantic Treaty Organisation leaders in Brussels was expected to be tense, given the widening rift in the Western alliance over the U.S.'s imposition of trade tariffs. But President Donald Trump's call to member-countries to double their annual defence expenditure to 4% of GDP has the potential for greater harm than his repeated denigration of NATO or his disregard for diplomatic niceties. European countries have for some time been smarting under Washington's persistent attack on their failure to honour the current commitment to raise their defence budgets to 2% of annual output by 2024. NATO members were reminded of the unequal burden-sharing within the organisation via letters despatched from the White House ahead of the summit. Mr. Trump can launch his latest offensive largely due to the latitude he enjoys on account of the U.S. spending well in excess of 3% of GDP on defence in 2017-18. He took aim especially at Germany, highlighting in particular the incongruity between its military spending and huge trade surplus with the U.S. A relatively recent dimension to the diatribe is the attack on Germany's large imports of gas from Russia, a divisive issue within Europe, particularly after the threats posed by Moscow's regional ambitions. Besides putting Chancellor Angela Merkel in a spot, it served to deflect attention from criticism across the Atlantic of Mr. Trump's proximity to Russian President Vladimir Putin and their bilateral meeting in Helsinki.

Notwithstanding Mr. Trump's claims, Europe's expenditure on defence has been on the rise since 2014, according to the International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS). One explanation for this shift is the security situation following Russia's annexation of Crimea. IISS data also show that Washington's commitment to Europe's security is just over 5% of the total U.S. defence budget. Within that, its contribution to NATO's common funding is an estimated 22.1%, besides investments in other initiatives. Some of Mr. Trump's predecessors in the White House had sought to address this imbalance, but without ever questioning the commitment of Washington's allies to the bloc's collective defence, or using it as a bargaining chip. Conversely, exploiting Europe's greater dependence on the U.S. security umbrella serves to bolster Mr. Trump's domestic nationalist constituency ahead of the November mid-term Congressional elections. While not all Republicans may approve of the President's offensive against American allies, many prefer to emphasise substance over style. The communiqué issued after the summit reiterates the group's resolve to meet the 2024 deadline on defence spending. But Mr. Trump seems impatient on achieving the target sooner, without spelling out his reasons. The world will learn more about Mr. Trump's America First agenda in the coming months.

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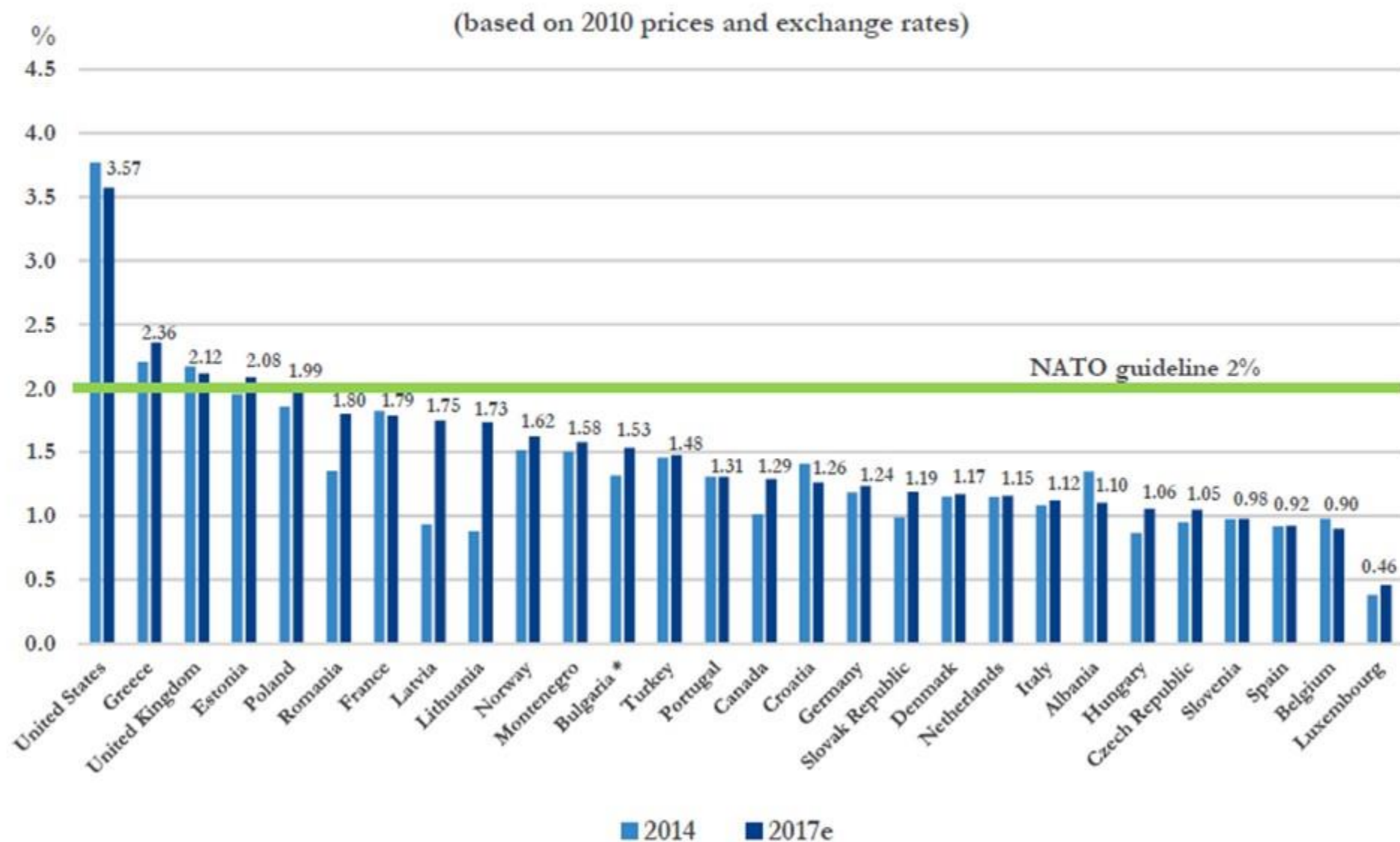
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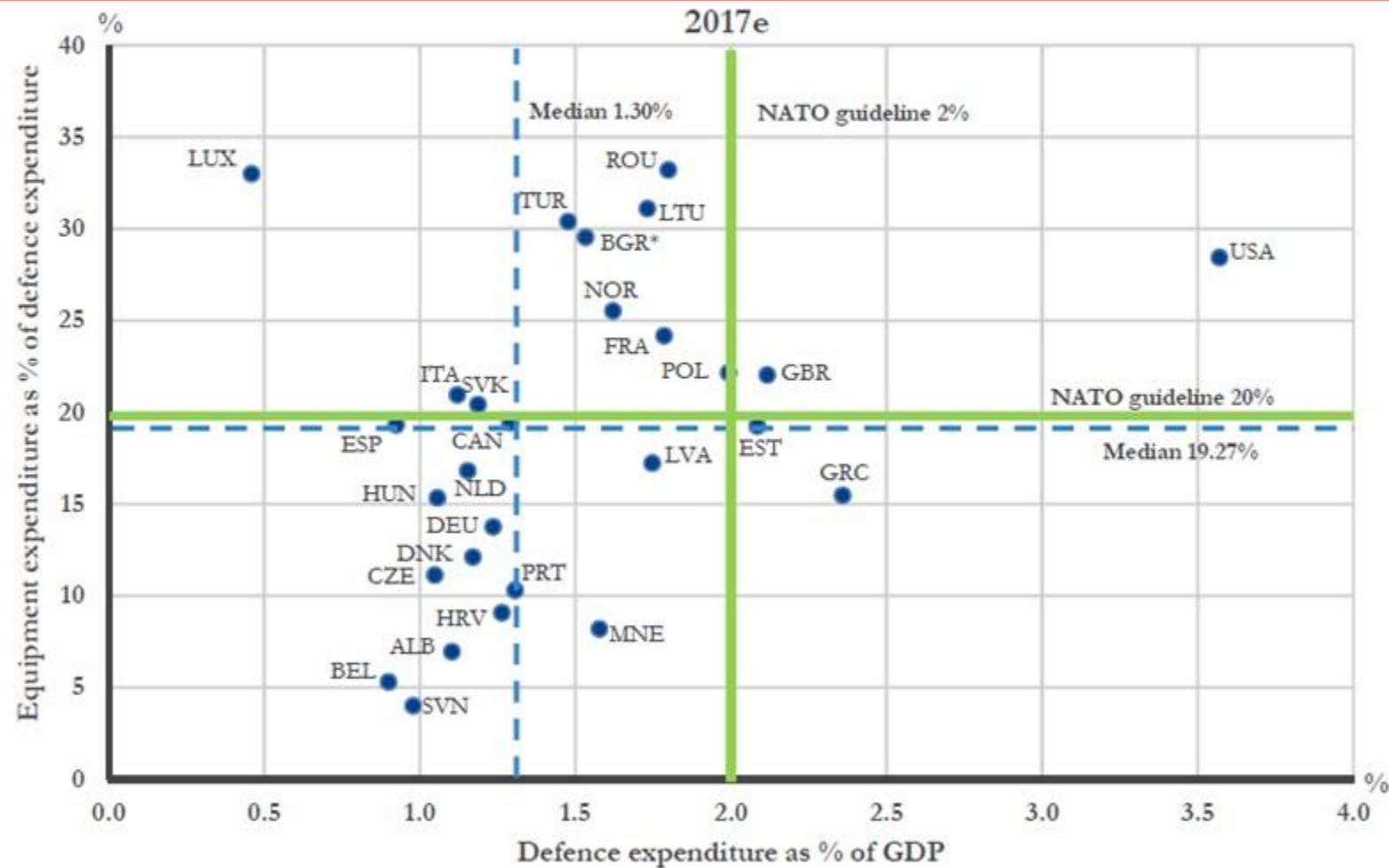
Important International institutions,
agencies and fora- their structure, mandate.



DEFENCE EXPENDITURE AS A SHARE OF GDP (%)



DEFENCE EXPENDITURE AS A SHARE OF GDP VERSUS EQUIPMENT EXPENDITURE AS A SHARE OF DEFENCE EXPENDITURE

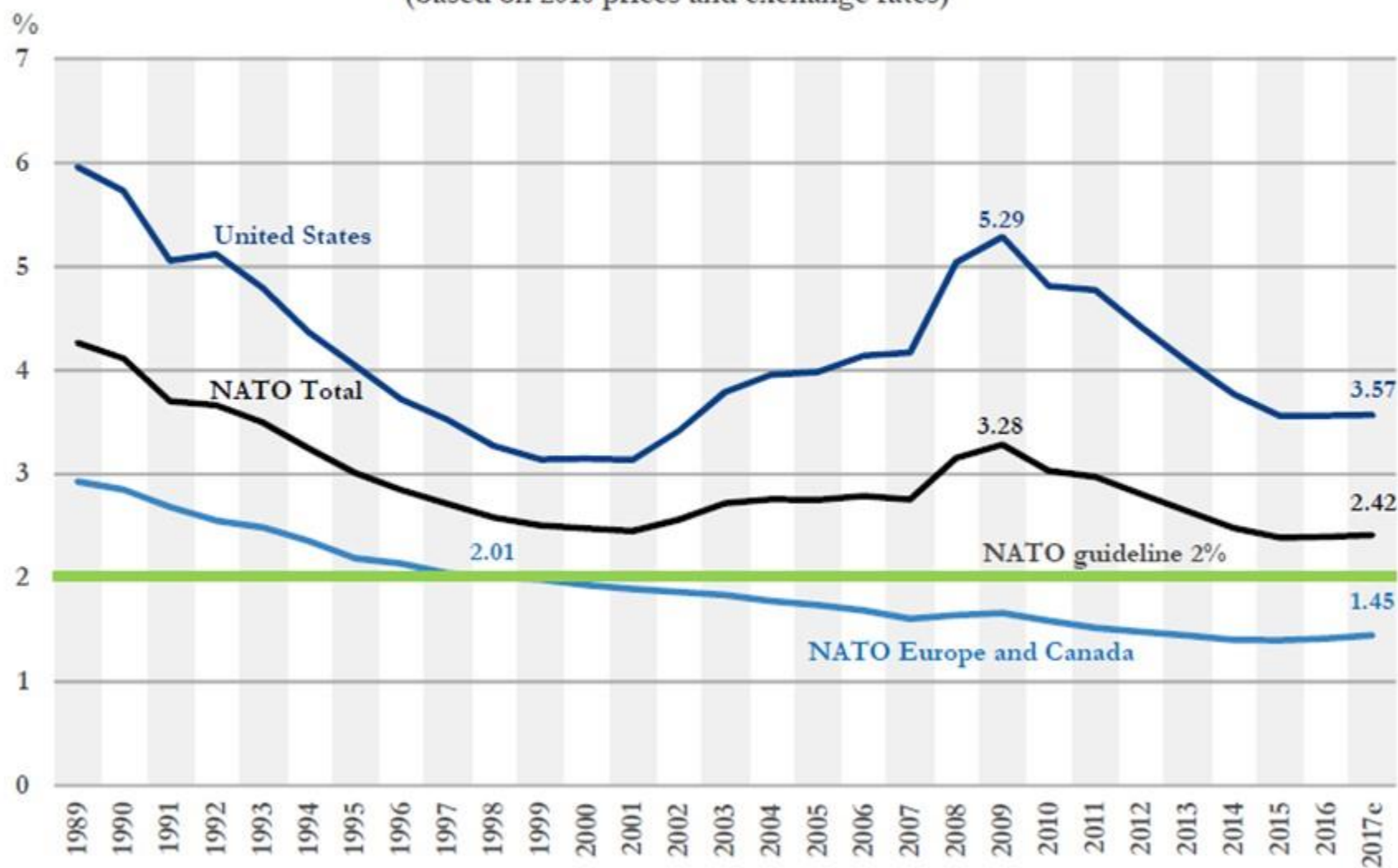


Notes: Figures for 2017 are estimates. The NATO Europe and Canada aggregate from 2017 includes Montenegro, which became an Ally on 5 June 2017.

* Defence expenditure does not include pensions.

DEFENCE EXPENDITURE AS A SHARE OF GDP (%)

(based on 2010 prices and exchange rates)



DEFENCE EXPENDITURE BY THE NATO COUNTRIES



- 1** These are the payments made by a National Government, specifically to meet the needs of its armed forces, those of Allies or of the Alliance.
- 2** Major component is payments on armed forces financed within the Ministry of Defence budget.
- 3** Armed forces include land, maritime and air forces as well as joint formations such as administration and command.

DEFENCE EXPENDITURE BY THE NATO COUNTRIES



PRESENT SCENARIO

- 1 US spends in excess of 3% of GDP on defence in 2017-18.
- 2 The target of US president is Germany. It spends much lesser military spending and at the same time, there is a huge trade surplus with the US.
- 3 Moreover, Germany imports gas from Russia, that is the divisive issue within Europe.

DEFENCE EXPENDITURE BY THE NATO COUNTRIES



WHAT HAPPENED IN RECENT TIMES SINCE 2014?

- 1 Since 2014, Europe's expenditure on defence is on rise.
- 2 This is primarily due to the security situation following Russia's annexation of Crimea.
- 3 Washington's commitment to Europe's security is just over 5% of the total US defence budget.
- 4 Within that, its contribution to NATO's common funding is an estimated 22.1%, besides investments in other initiatives.

DEFENCE EXPENDITURE BY THE NATO COUNTRIES



Donald Trump



HOW TO VIEW THIS DECISION?

- 1 Predecessors of Trump never questioned the commitment of Washington's allies to the bloc's collective defence.
- 2 Exploiting Europe's greater dependence on U.S. security umbrella is to satisfy the National Constituency of US, ahead of the November mid-term Congressional elections.
- 3 The communique issued after the Summit reiterates the group's resolve to meet the 2024 deadline on defence spending.

Under these circumstances, Trump's step appears to be hasty and to satisfy the nationalist constituency ahead of the November mid-term Congressional elections.

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